

Reported AI use by business size

A clear baseline for how widely UK businesses report using AI-based technologies.

Reported AI-use point estimates rise from 37.4% for micro businesses to 50.8% for small and 57.1% for medium businesses.

Evidence scope

Table 42 describes all UK businesses within each published size group. Micro, small and medium businesses are the primary scope; large businesses are a reference benchmark.

UKBDS Official source DSIT 2026	95% Uncertainty Intervals retained	SMEs Primary scope Large shown separately
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Executive summary

37.4% Micro 35.4-39.5%	50.8% Small 46.6-54.9%	57.1% Medium 50.0-64.3%	78.2% Large* 70.7-85.7%
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The point estimates show a consistent size gradient across the published categories. This is useful for market segmentation and service design because a single 'SME adoption rate' would conceal material differences between micro, small and medium businesses.

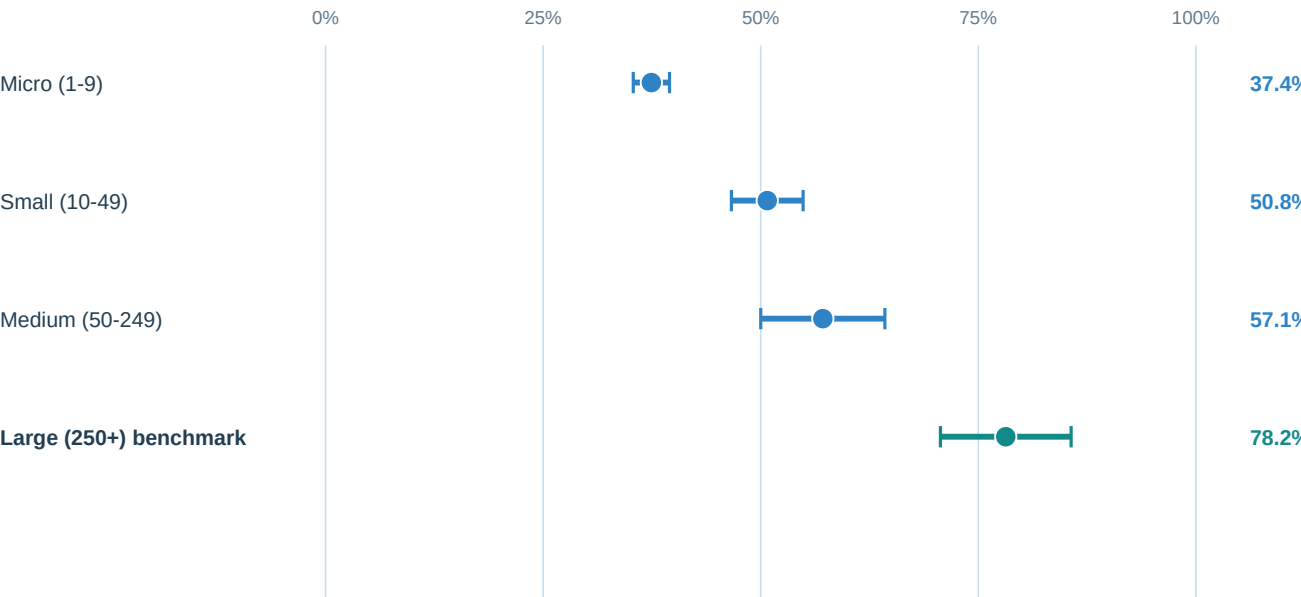
What the evidence supports

Size matters for the baseline Micro businesses have the lowest point estimate among the three SME groups; medium businesses have the highest.	The benchmark is distinct The 78.2% large-business estimate provides context, but large businesses are not included in the core SME finding.
Uncertainty remains visible Intervals widen for medium and large groups, reflecting smaller rounded respondent bases.	The result is about reported use It does not show frequency, effectiveness, depth of integration or return on investment.

Business implication: compare organisations with the most relevant size group before discussing sector, use case or implementation depth.

Evidence by business size

Point estimates with supplied 95% confidence intervals.



Business size	Estimate	95% interval	Rounded base
Micro (1-9)	37.4%	35.4-39.5%	2,500
Small (10-49)	50.8%	46.6-54.9%	680
Medium (50-249)	57.1%	50.0-64.3%	220
Large (250+) benchmark	78.2%	70.7-85.7%	130

* Large businesses are shown as a separately labelled reference benchmark. Rounded bases are respondents, not counts of UK businesses.

Decision use: a baseline, not a diagnosis

The survey result is most useful as a starting point for better questions. It does not diagnose an individual firm or prescribe a technology purchase.

For micro businesses Which low-complexity, repeatable tasks could justify experimentation without creating unnecessary data or governance risk?	For small businesses Which successful experiments are ready to move into recurring workflows, with clear ownership and human review?
For medium businesses Where should integration, governance and workforce capability be strengthened as use becomes more widespread?	For advisers and policymakers Do support offers distinguish between basic use, system integration and organisational governance rather than treating adoption as binary?

Recommended next cuts

- Repeat the baseline by the source's published sector categories where sample bases and suppression permit.
- Separate experimentation, recurring workflow use and system integration.
- Pair the adoption baseline with use-case, governance and operational pathway evidence.
- Avoid converting the percentage into an estimate of business counts without an appropriate population denominator and survey design treatment.

Useful insight: the size gradient is a segmentation signal. It is not proof that size causes adoption or that every difference is statistically significant.

Method, interpretation and source trail

These reports retain the survey definitions rather than treating every percentage as directly comparable.

Source and fieldwork

Department for Science, Innovation and Technology, UK Business Data Survey 2026. Fieldwork ran from 10 October 2025 to 28 January 2026. Source tables used: Table 42.

Denominator

All UK businesses within each published business-size category.

Uncertainty and bases

The official central estimates and supplied 95% confidence intervals are shown. Unweighted sample bases are rounded respondent counts, not counts of UK businesses. The medium and large groups generally have wider intervals because their bases are smaller.

Interpretation limits

- The findings are descriptive. They do not establish causation or business impact.
- The published package does not provide the covariance, replicate weights, raw microdata or official pairwise method needed for a fully defensible size-group significance test.
- Large businesses are a separate benchmark and are not part of the primary SME result.
- The measure records use of any listed AI-based technology; it does not distinguish occasional experimentation from embedded operational use.

Official material

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 publication](#)

[UK Business Data Survey 2026 technical report](#)

Use this evidence as a disciplined starting point for questions and prioritisation - not as a substitute for organisation-specific assessment.